DAILY EDITORIAL SUMMARY

04th May 2026

Topics to be covered:

- ✓ **Rising Screen Time in Children**
- ✓ **A Countdown to International Yoga Day**
- ✓ **Doctors Decide: On Legal Abortion**
- ✓ **Keeping India's Carbon Money at Home**

To access the video of Editorial Summary:

JOIN WHATSAPP

JOIN TELEGRAM

Topics

Rising Screen Time in Children

Subject: GS 1: Social Issues, GS 2: Government Policies and Interventions for Development in various sectors and Issues arising out of their Design and Implementation.

Context:

An AIIMS New Delhi study finds that **excessive screen time in children below one year may raise the risk of autism-r**elated symptoms by age three.

AIIMS Report on Screen Time and Autism

- **Study Focus:** Conducted on 250 children; found significant observations in 150 of them.
- **Key Finding:** Increasing screen time in children aged 0 to 3 years shows a major correlation with the onset of **Autism** symptoms by the age of 3.
- **Autism Characteristics:** Developmental disorders affecting thinking, understanding, social skills, and the ability to interact with others.
  - While not a direct cause-effect proof yet, there is a strong correlation necessitating further research.

About 'Screen Time in Children':

- Screen time is the **time children spend using devices like phones,** TVs, tablets, and computers.

Scientific Basis: How Screen Harms Developing Brain?

- **Early Brain Plasticity (0–3 Years):** The first three years are marked by rapid brain development and intense formation of neural connections, making this phase highly critical.
  - The brain is like **"wet clay" at this age; it** takes the shape of the environment it is exposed to.
- **Attention Span: Fast-paced** and highly **stimulating content** trains the brain to seek **constant engagement**.
  - This can reduce a child's ability to **focus** on **real-world activities** requiring sustained attention.
- **Language Development:** Early **language acquisition** depends on **active listening** and **two-way communication** with caregivers.
  - **Passive screen viewing** reduces **verbal interaction**, which may lead to **delayed speech** and weaker **language skills**.
- **Melatonin (Sleep Regulation):** Screen exposure, especially at night, emits **blue light** that suppresses **melatonin** (the **sleep hormone**).
  - This disrupts **sleep patterns** and can negatively affect **brain development**.
- **Dopamine Dependency:** Constant stimulation from cartoons/shorts leads to a dopamine release loop, causing addiction.
- **Passive Learning:** Screens make children "passive learners," whereas interacting with parents creates vital neural connections and language skills.

Official Guidelines (WHO & Indian Academy of Pediatrics)

- **0–18 Months:** Zero screen time (no mobile, TV, or tablets).
- **Ideally up to 3 Years:** No screen time is recommended for optimal development.
- **3–5 Years:** Maximum of **1 hour per day** of quality content only.

Root Causes of Increased Screen Time:

- **Accessibility:** Cheap smartphones and internet data.
- **Shift in Family Structure:** Move from joint families (where many relatives could mind a child) to nuclear families and dual-income households.

- **Platform Design:** YouTube/Social media "Auto-play" features that keep children hooked.
- **Post-COVID Impact:** Digitization of education and the "all-in-one" nature of mobile devices.
- **Urbanization:** Lack of outdoor play spaces and playgrounds in cities.
- **Parental Misconception:** Using the phone as a "Digital Baby Sitter" to keep children occupied while parents work or cook.

Major Challenges:

- **Cognitive Development:** Weak memory, poor critical thinking, and reduced attention span.
- **Physical Health:** Obesity due to lack of outdoor activity and early need for eyeglasses.
- **Emotional & Behavioral:** Issues with anger, anxiety, and becoming stubborn/irritable.
- **Social Skills:** Inability to learn sharing, cooperation, and how to talk to other children.
- **Academic:** Difficulty focusing on studies due to the desire for "instant gratification" found in short-form content.
- **Digital Divide:** A gap between those overusing technology and those in rural areas lacking access.

Government & Institutional Initiatives:

- **Karnataka Digital Detox Policy 2026:** Aims to restrict social media and limit child screen time to 1 hour.
- **NEP 2020 / NCERT / CBSE:** Including Cyber Safety and Digital Citizenship in the school curriculum.
- **No Gadget Hours:** Models adopted by schools in Karnataka and Kerala.
- **Khel India Program:** Government focus on encouraging physical sports to reduce screen dependency.

Way Forward:

- **Effective Implementation**: Strictly follow WHO and Pediatrician guidelines for zero screen time under age 2.
- **Parental Awareness:** Parents should watch content *with* children rather than giving them the device alone.
- **Community Involvement:** Using Aanganwadi workers to educate parents at the grassroots level.
- **Regulation:** Regulating tech platforms to prevent addictive algorithms targeting children.
- **Infrastructure:** Strengthening outdoor infrastructure and play areas.

Key Words:

- **Digital Baby Sitter**: Use of screens/devices to occupy or calm children in place of active caregiving.
- **Early Brain Plasticity**: The brain's **high adaptability** in early years, where experiences strongly shape **neural development**.
- **Dopamine Dependency Loop**: A cycle where **instant digital rewards** trigger repeated **dopamine release**, reinforcing screen-seeking behavior.
- **Passive Content Consumption**: Viewing content without **interaction or engagement**, limiting **active learning**.
- **Digital Detox**: A deliberate break from **screen use** to restore **mental focus and well-being**.
- **Algorithmic Addiction**: Engagement driven by **algorithms** that continuously serve **personalized, attention-grabbing content**.
- **Cognitive Pause**: A moment of **mental rest or reflection** that allows the brain to **process information and recover focus**.

Mains Practice:

Q. The rising screen time among children is no longer just a lifestyle issue; it is a profound developmental and public health crisis. Analyze the psychological and physical impacts of excessive screen exposure on children. Suggest comprehensive policy measures to mitigate this challenge. (250 Words, 15 Marks)

A Countdown to International Yoga Day

GS2: Issues related to Health

Context:

In a world facing **conflict, uncertainty, and rising stress**, **yoga emerges as a means to cultivate inner peace**, complementing external efforts to achieve lasting harmony.

Background and International Recognition of Yoga:

- **International Yoga Day:** Celebrated on 21st June; it is considered an amazing gift of India's heritage.
- **UN Proposal (2014):** Prime Minister Modi proposed the International Day of Yoga at the **69th session of the UN General Assembly**.
- **First Celebration (2015):** The first International Day of Yoga was held in 2015 with the theme **"Yoga for Harmony and Peace."**
- **UNESCO Recognition (2016):** Yoga was included in the **UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity**.
- **2018 Theme: "Yoga for Peace."**

Aspect	Tangible Art	Intangible Art
Meaning	Art that has a **physical form** and can be **seen or touched**	Art that exists as **skills, expressions, or traditions** without physical form
Nature	**Concrete and material-based**	**Abstract and experience-based**
Examples	Paintings, sculptures, monuments	Music, dance, oral traditions, yoga practices
Preservation	Preserved through **museums, galleries, and conservation techniques**	Preserved through **practice, transmission, and cultural continuity**

Government Initiatives

- **The Ministry of Ayush** promotes yoga through public health, education, and community programmes.
- Events such as **'Yoga Mahotsav 2026'** aim to encourage **collective participation and long-term behavioural change**.

How Yoga Helps?

- **Accessibility:** The biggest strength of Yoga is its simplicity—"Lay down the mat and get started."
- **Emotional Regulation:** Helps control anger, irritability, and impulsive reactions.,
- **The "Cognitive Pause":** Meditation and Yoga create a **gap/space** between **stimulation** (an event) and **response** (reaction).
- **Decision Making:** This 2-second pause allows for thoughtful control over thoughts and better decision-making rather than acting on impulse.

Victor Frankl Quote: Explained

"Between stimulation and response... there is a space. In that space is our power to choose our response."

The quote by Viktor Frankl highlights that between any **stimulus (external event)** and our **response**, there exists a **mental space** where choice is possible.

- In the context of **yoga**, this "space" is consciously developed through practices like **meditation, pranayama (breath control), and mindfulness**. Yoga trains the mind to **pause rather than react instantly**, allowing individuals to respond with **awareness, balance, and clarity** instead of impulse.
- Thus, yoga expands this inner space, strengthening **self-control and emotional regulation**, which transforms reactions into **thoughtful responses**—a key foundation for **inner peace and harmonious social behaviour**.

Yoga as Soft Power:

- **Soft Power Concept**: Defined by **Joseph Nye;** it is the capacity to influence others through attraction rather than force (Hard Power).
- **Hard Power vs. Soft Power:** Hard power uses military strength or sanctions, while soft power uses culture, like Bollywood, Cricket, and Yoga, to build a positive image of a country.,
- **Global Connection:** Just as Afghanistan has a "Soft Power" connection with India through Bollywood and Cricket, Yoga has the power to generate global love and respect for India.,

Conclusion:

- **Peace is not just** an external achievement but a continuous process shaped by individual behaviour. Yoga provides a practical pathway to cultivate inner peace, which in turn contributes to global harmony.
- Thus, yoga represents a **sustainable and enduring architecture of peace** in the modern world.

Mains Practice:

Q. Yoga has evolved from an ancient Indian discipline to a potent instrument of India's soft power. Discuss how cultural diplomacy fosters global trust and societal cohesion in an increasingly fragmented world. (150 Words, 10 Marks)

Doctors Decide: On Legal Abortion

GS PAPER II: Mechanisms, laws, institutions and bodies constituted for the protection and betterment of these vulnerable sections.

Context:

The third topic discussed in the editorial is **Reproductive Rights and the Legal/Medical Aspects of Abortion** in India.

The Recent Case and Supreme Court Ruling

The discussion centers on a case involving a 15-year-old rape survivor who was 30 weeks pregnant.

- **Supreme Court Decision:** The Court allowed the abortion, reasoning that as a rape survivor, she did not conceive by choice and should have the right to terminate.
- **Court's Logic:** The Court feared that if denied, the girl might seek an unsafe abortion from an unqualified person ("jholachhap doctor"), posing an even greater risk.

Legal Framework: Medical Termination of Pregnancy (MTP) Act, 1971

The sources outline the legal guidelines for aborting a pregnancy based on its gestational age (number of weeks):

- **Up to 20 weeks:** Abortion is generally permissible with the opinion of **one doctor**.
- **20 to 24 weeks:** Abortion is allowed in **special cases** (e.g., rape survivors) but requires the opinion of **two doctors**.
- **Beyond 24 weeks:** Termination is considered highly risky. It requires the constitution of a **Medical Board**, and abortion can only proceed with their specific approval.

Conflict of Rights: Reproductive Autonomy vs. Medical Safety

The case highlights a significant conflict between the mother's rights and medical reality:

- **Advanced Stage Risks:** At 30 weeks, the fetus is almost fully developed and could potentially survive in an NICU if delivered via C-section.
- **Danger to Mother:** Doctors warn that abortion at this late stage is medically unsafe and can lead to severe complications like excessive bleeding or death.
- **Expertise Gap:** The author suggests that the Supreme Court may have lacked medical expertise and failed to fully weigh the **Medical Board's** concerns regarding the life-threatening risks to the young girl.

Systemic and Institutional Failures:

The case reveals several failures within the administrative and legal system:

- **Late Detection:** The fact that a 15-year-old reached 30 weeks of pregnancy before seeking a legal remedy is a "slap" on the system.
- **Lack of Coordination:** There was a failure in coordination between **hospitals, police, and POCSO Act protocols**, which should have triggered earlier intervention.
- **Social Stigma:** Fear of social stigma often leads to the non-reporting of rape, resulting in late detection of resulting pregnancies.

Rights vs Reality:

- Providing rights without ensuring **safety** can lead to **"false empowerment"**
- If the procedure risks the woman's life, the **value of rights is undermined.**

Way Forward:

- **Medical Board First:** The opinion of medical experts should be prioritized in late-stage cases because they understand the physical risks better than a layperson or the court.
- **Early Detection and Reporting:** Systems must be improved to ensure rape cases and pregnancies in minors are identified and reported much earlier.
- **Institutional Synergy:** Better coordination is needed between police, healthcare providers, and the legal system to take swift action.
- **Counseling and Support:** Survivors and their parents need professional counseling to understand the medical risks and receive emotional support throughout the process.
- **Rights with Safety:** Providing the "right" to an abortion without ensuring medical safety is described as **"false empowerment"**; a right is only valuable if the survivor survives the procedure.

Key Concepts

- **Gestational Age**: Refers to the **number of weeks of pregnancy**.
- **Clinical Review**: The **medical opinion of doctors** regarding whether abortion is safe or advisable.
- **Reproductive Autonomy:** Reproductive autonomy refers to a woman's fundamental right to decide whether to give birth and how many children to have.
  - This is protected under **Article 21** of the Indian Constitution as part of the right to life and personal liberty.
  - Furthermore, the **K.S. Puttaswamy case** judgment on the right to privacy also emphasized **bodily autonomy** as a core right.

Conclusion:

- The issue reflects a **delicate balance between reproductive rights and medical safety**.
- A **holistic approach** combining **legal safeguards, medical expertise, and institutional efficiency** is essential to ensure both **dignity and safety of women**.

Mains Practice:

Q. In the debate over medical termination of pregnancy, a careful balance must be struck between a woman's reproductive autonomy and the clinical risks associated with advanced gestational age. Critically analyze this statement in light of recent Supreme Court observations regarding minor rape victims.

(250 Words, 15 Marks)

Keeping India's Carbon Money at Home

GS PAPER III: Environmental Pollution and Degradation.

Context:

The article mainly focuses on **Europe**, particularly the **European Union (EU)** and its new policy called the **Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM)**.

What is CBAM?

- The EU has introduced CBAM **to ensure that imported goods also face carbon costs, similar to domestic** producers.
- Within the EU, industries are required to **limit emissions** or **purchase carbon credits** if they exceed limits.
- However, countries like **India** produce goods (e.g., steel) at lower costs due to **less strict emission rules**, creating **unfair competition**.
- To address this, the EU imposes a **carbon tax on imports** based on emissions generated during production.

Core Issue for India

- **Indian companies** exporting to the EU will have to pay carbon tax to the EU, leading to:
  - Increased cost of exports
  - Reduced competitiveness
- **Concern: Why should this tax revenue go to the EU instead of India?**

India's Response (FTA Negotiations)

India negotiated two key safeguards in its agreement with the EU:

1. **No Double Taxation**
   - If a company has **already paid carbon tax in India**, it will **not be taxed again in the EU**.
2. **Future Exemption Clause**
   - If the EU grants **exemptions to any other country**, **India will automatically receive the same benefit**.

Way Forward:

- **Strengthen Carbon Market**
  - Improve implementation of **Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (2023)**
  - Companies emitting more must **buy credits**, while low emitters can **sell credits**
- **Introduce Indian CBAM**
  - India can implement its own **Border Carbon Adjustment Mechanism** to:
    - ✓ **Protect domestic industries**
    - ✓ Encourage **lower emissions**
    - ✓ Enhance India's **global climate leadership image**

Conclusion:

- The key idea is to retain "carbon money" within India rather than losing it to external mechanisms like the EU's CBAM.
- Strengthening domestic systems and creating a **reciprocal mechanism** can ensure both **economic and environmental benefits**.

❍❍❍❍

CUSTOMER SERVICE

PW Web/App: https://smart.link/7wwosivoicgd4

For more such content, subscribe to our Telegram Channel https://t.me/pw_upsc

JOIN WHATSAPP

JOIN TELEGRAM